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Embedded spatial learning: Bringing studio to site

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How do students in landscape architecture best learn to investigate sites and the complexities of the layered conditions they contain? And how do they conceptualize and design responses to these situations that both solve problems and create spatial experiences?

In design studios landscape architecture students typically develop their analysis and design work through various representational tools such as maps, drawings, photographs and models. The common representational modes are to some extent given and feature substantial techniques important for design work, but they can also cause a dilemma and a gap in the teaching setup in terms of site understanding and site response. To address these types of projects differently, teaching formats and studios including live-projects and the construction of physical interventions are a way of adding methods to the more classic modes of analysis and design proposals.

At the Urban Intervention Studio (UIS), we attempt to bridge the gap through a studio setup where students explore a specific site throughout the course and where (part of) their design response becomes full-scale local actions through spatial 1:1 interventions. It does not teach students all about the relationship between site and solution, but our experience is that the embedded situation of the course brings valuable lessons of how to merge and translate multifaceted site analysis into site designs.

Throughout its lifetime from 2012 until today, the UIS course has developed and adapted to various conditions, collaborative setups and sites. However, a series of design pedagogic frameworks are stable and continuously refined. The initial site analysis based on experimental mapping, a panel and dialogue debate with the most important stakeholders, the urban breakfast salon that frames onsite dialogues, the mock-up midterm with presentation and testing of rough prototypes as well as the final vernissage are recurrent elements of the course. By taking a point of departure in an embodied site analysis, various scalar approaches and by manifesting the thoughts in physical installations, we seek to explore the field of design pedagogy in terms of the methodological spectrum and the site challenges addressed, supplementing established representational modes and engagement methods.

Each year the course changes site and focus based on current urban agendas and challenges. Whereas during the earlier years of the course we addressed creative rethinking and activation of vacant areas in the city, we now increasingly address other types of sites such as housing areas affected by urban redevelopment or existing cultural and educational institutions in need of rethinking their relation to the city. We relocate our studio to the site setting-up working spaces locally in places that can be anything from a former military station, a run-down warehouse, to a culture house or a contemporary office space depending on the possibilities and character of the site. The studio itself becomes part of the site, which means that we can apply structured site studies easily, but the constant presence also means that the atmospheres and conditions are soaked up just through being there.

The Urban Intervention Studio is rooted in a phenomenological tradition where the sensuous embodied experience is complimented by exploration of social and strategic local agendas. Two notions of site-specificity frame this approach where the multiple layers of context are termed as being: 1) that of the phenomenological spatial experiential and, 2) that of the cultural, social and historical (Kwoon 2004). Both options shape the site analysis of the Urban Intervention Studio and both are applied as departure points for design interventions. On-site perceptual readings of spatial qualities and atmospheres is complimented by a strategic investigation via engaging local stakeholders and integrating historic conditions, policy documents along potential visions for the site.

The setup of the Urban Intervention Studio seeks to develop methods of site understanding that link and activate across scales and relate to experiential aspects as well as more overall urban development agendas. These poles meet on site and in dialogue with the site. The studio format allows us to research and test in a 'real life' laboratory how interpretation of a locality can translate into urban objects and how these urban objects interface and thus impact a particular site.

The brief the students are given provides a design challenge that addresses particular local issues and potentials always with the notion of shaping new public domains. Installations must create potential hubs for social interactions and for affording behavioural uses while simultaneously relating to the culture and historic traces of the local site through adding new layers of accessibility, experience, and meaning. It can be an attractor that draws us in, a setting that invites us to take a rest, an object that lets us experience the surroundings in a new way or a scenography that invites us to play and interact.

In 2016, we set up the studio at Lynetten Peninsula, a past military site now transformed into a theatre space. Here students' urban interventions responded to the current site conditions of both being an industrial derelict site and a potential cultural hub for urban interactions. In Theatre Quay a former small loading crane was converted into a swing hovering over the waterfront reprogramming a new logic onto a harbour industry relict. Water Within Reach addressed the relation between the harbour edge and the water surface through an intervention of wood decks descending stone boulders towards the water. Motus was a textile intervention that re-activated a series of abandoned lighting poles giving form to